Story: Tell Me About Yourself (Intro)

Practice date: 2026-11-06. Prompt: "Tell me about yourself."

The story in Shridhar's words (facts)

Started his career as a software development engineer at Amazon, after a bachelor's and a master's in computer science (PICT BE 2005-2009, UT Dallas MS CS 2010-2012, MIT Sloan EMBA completed May 2026). Spent eleven years at Amazon (2012-2023), where he designed Alexa's multi-agent architecture, the framework that lets Alexa switch between agents in a conversation. Before that he worked on the speech to text and text to speech groups, and launched Alexa Voice Shopping across ten countries. At Amazon he had 35+ direct reports and 110+ partner-team reports across 8+ countries.

Moved from Seattle to Boston for his wife's pathology residency at Beth Israel. That move is where he started looking for opportunities to apply his data science and AI knowledge in a new space, and he ended up at Moderna. At Moderna (Senior Director of AI, 2023 to present) he leads a 35+ engineer AI organization across data science, data engineering, and software engineering. His most recent project extracts knowledge from more than a million documents and presents it to users in a user-friendly way.

He is looking for a new challenge because he wants to grow further in hardcore tech areas, and an Engineering Manager seat at a big tech company (Google, Amazon, or similar) is where that growth is. Moderna is in a phase where it is pausing digital advancement while it focuses on the commercial phase of drug release.

What went well in the mock

- The arc lands: Amazon to Alexa's multi-agent work, then the move to Moderna to apply AI to real health problems, then the pull toward hands-on engineering leadership. The interviewer can follow the through-line without effort.
- The Boston move has a human reason that is easy to remember and easy to respect.
- The million-document project is concrete and current, and it is the one detail an interviewer is most likely to probe next.
- The enthusiasm is genuine. "I'm super excited to be here" reads as real, not rehearsed.

What went wrong in the mock

- The opening was a thank-you, not a headline. The interviewer had to wait for the substance. Open with who you are and what you lead, then thank them.
- Team scale never surfaced. He said he leads the data science, data engineering, and software engineering teams, but never said 35+ engineers, and never said 35+ direct reports and 110+ partner-team reports at Amazon. For an EM loop, scale is a credential, and it was missing.
- Technical depth was thin. Speech to text, text to speech, and multi-agent were named but not explained: no mention of what the multi-agent framework actually does, no scale on Voice Shopping (ten countries), no mention of the 30+ production LLM applications at Moderna.
- "Currently I'm stagnant here" and "Moderna is pausing digital advancements" can read as a complaint about the current employer. The reason to leave should be framed as a pull toward the next growth, not a push away from a stalled org.
- The close never connected to the target. The answer ended on Moderna's commercial phase

instead of on why an EM seat at a big tech company is the right next step.

- Small factual slip: the residency is pathology at Beth Israel, not "Harvard Medical College."

The ideal answer (~2 minutes spoken)

"Thank you for taking the time to talk to me. I'm excited to be here. I am Shridhar Pathak, and I lead AI engineering. I started my career as a software development engineer at Amazon, after a bachelor's and a master's in computer science, and spent eleven years there. The work I am proudest of was designing Alexa's multi-agent architecture, the framework that lets Alexa switch between agents in the middle of a conversation. Before that I worked on the speech to text and text to speech groups, and I launched Alexa Voice Shopping across ten countries. By the end I had thirty-five plus direct reports and a hundred and ten plus partner-team reports across eight countries.

In twenty twenty-three I moved to Boston for my wife's pathology residency at Beth Israel, and that is where I started looking for opportunities to apply my data science and AI knowledge in a new space. I ended up at Moderna, where I lead a thirty-five plus engineer AI organization across data science, data engineering, and software engineering, delivering thirty plus production LLM applications. My most recent project extracts knowledge from more than a million documents and presents it to users in a user-friendly way.

I am looking for a new challenge because I want to grow further in hardcore tech areas, and an engineering manager seat at a big tech company is where that growth is. I want to be building again, close to the technology and close to the team."

Likely follow-ups, with the honest answers

- "Why would you step down from Senior Director to an EM seat?": "Because the growth I want is hands-on. I want to be close to the technology and close to the team again, and an EM seat at a big tech company is the role that gets me there. Title is not the goal. Building is."
- "What did the multi-agent architecture actually do?": "Alexa used to hand a whole conversation to one agent. The framework I designed lets Alexa switch between agents in the middle of a conversation, so the right agent handles each turn. It was the first multi-agent conversational switching framework at Alexa, built from zero to one."
- "Tell me about the million-document project.": "We extract knowledge from more than a million documents and present it to users in a user-friendly way. The hard part is not the extraction, it is making the answer trustworthy and usable for people who are not engineers."
- "Why Moderna, and why leave now?": "I moved to Boston for my wife's residency and wanted to apply AI to a new space. Moderna gave me that, and I built a real AI organization there. Now Moderna is focused on the commercial phase of drug release, and I want my next growth to be in hardcore tech, which is what an EM seat at a big tech company offers."